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PODCAST

« To improve my game, I have to play with people who are better than me rather than those I know I can beat »

ANAHAT SINGH

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Anahat Singh caught the nation's attention in 2022 when she participated in the last Commonwealth Games in Birmingham as the youngest member of the Indian team. Since then, she has proved multiple times that she is a potential star in the making. The 17-year-old is now a two-time national champion and the country's top-ranked (World No. 62) female player in the sport.

Under the guidance of a coaching team comprising Gregory Gaultier (Former World No. 1), Stephane Galifi (Former World No. 40), and mentor Saurav Ghosal (Former World No. 10), along with support from JSW Sports, the Delhi girl has made tremendous progress at the senior level. And there is more to come.

Currently studying in Class 11, Anahat is part of the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (Development Group) and is arguably India's best medal hope when the sport makes its Olympic debut in Los Angeles in 2028.

In an exclusive chat with *Sportstar*, she reflects on the transition from the junior level to the senior circuit, qualifying for her maiden World Championships (May 9-17 in Chicago), balancing squash and academics, and the Olympic dream.

You played at the Commonwealth Games at the age of 14 in 2022 and, the following year, won two bronze medals at the Asian Games. How did those experiences, so early in your career, shape your journey in the sport?

Playing at such events is huge. Doing it at such a young age was possibly one of the best experiences and learning moments for me. By going there and spending time with seniors from all sports, not just squash, I understood what their daily routine is like.

Winning two medals at the Asian Games at any age would be a big deal, but getting them so early in my career is something I'll never forget. At that point, I thought I was playing quite well — but two years later, if I watch that video, I feel I was playing terribly. I've improved a lot since then, and one of the biggest reasons would be because of those two events.

In the last one and a half years, you began the transition from juniors to seniors. You played many PSA Challenger Tour events and did extremely well. What kind of changes did you make in terms of training, fitness, preparation and scheduling?

Earlier, I was playing both junior and senior events. I'm still playing juniors, but not on the Indian circuit — mostly just international tournaments. It's given me more time to focus on what's important, rather than just travelling all the time, from tournament to tournament.

It's not about playing events where I'm sure I would win and not really getting much practice. It's more about those that help improve my ranking, offer more practice, and experience as well.

Also, in terms of training, I have clearer goals now. I'm not just training aimlessly — I have tournaments to look forward to. I know who I'm going to play, and it's going to be a big competition for me.

The time I'm putting on court would honestly be a bit less because I've got school and travelling going on, but it's more focused. It's more about quality over quantity.

I've started working in the gym a lot more. I wasn't doing anything earlier, but now, slowly, I'm getting into it. I'm still not used to it — I get very tired and complain a lot, but I realise that at the end of the day, it's beneficial for me.

Also, I didn't have a constant coach when I was playing juniors until last year. Now, I have Grégory Gaultier, a